



Plant focus: ferns

Perfect for shady gardens, ferns form carpets of textured foliage that provide a decorative foil for woodland flowers.

RANGING FROM TINY CREEPING PLANTS, such as the Himalayan maidenhair fern, to the tall, stately royal fern, which reaches up to 6ft (2m) in height, this group of sun-shy woodland plants offers the gardener many exciting design opportunities. Ferns are grown primarily for their textured foliage, which provides a lacy backdrop to spring bulbs and other shade-tolerant blooms. For continuous color and interest throughout the year, mix evergreen ferns, such as Christmas fern, with deciduous ferns, which produce coiled shoots as their leaves unfurl in spring and turn rusty brown in fall. Although most ferns prefer damp soil, a few, such as the *Polypodium* family and male fern, do well in drier conditions and are invaluable for providing understory planting beneath trees and large shrubs.

Ferns create a luscious green blanket in cool shady areas where few other plants will thrive.



USING FERNS

Ferns look delicate, with their fine lacy foliage, but most are very cold tolerant and have many uses. They are also highly varied, offering solid or finely divided, glossy or matte green leaves, some decorated with purple or silver variegation. They look most effective planted together in shady borders, but many also make good specimen plants in containers, such as soft shield fern, with its elegant arching fronds.



Shade-loving astilbes and coral bells provide the perfect planting partners for lady fern and other ferns in a mixed border where the soil is moist.



Ferns of different sizes and shapes, such as hart's tongue fern and male fern, make excellent subjects for a textural foliage container.

